modern walling and a protective railing to stop you falling into the abyss.

Above the caves the path widens out on to an open, grassy plateau soaked in mist. If this mist was not so thick the view across the great void behind you would, I suspect, be pretty spectacular, because this is the ancient Naneghat Pass, which sits like a cleft on the watershed of the Western Ghats. Whatever rain falls east of this barrier drains away across the Deccan to join either the Godavari or the Bhima, the upper course of the Krishna.

The Naneghat Pass takes its name from what at first glance looks like a small Buddhist stupa set beside the path. This turns out to be a large stone container made out of two sections of carved stone. It was used to collect tolls from travellers who used the pass. *Nane* means ‘coins’ in Marathi and *ghat* in this context means ‘pass’, hence ‘toll-pass’.

The cave at the top of the Naneghat Pass first came to the notice of the scholarly world in the form of a letter dated 1 August 1828 written by Colonel William Sykes, subsequently read to the members of the Bombay Literary Society under the title of ‘Inscriptions of the Boodh [Buddhist] caves near Joonur’.[1] For the previous four years Sykes had been employed collecting statistical information from the Bombay Presidency, very much as Buchanan and Mackenzie had done earlier in Madras and Bengal. This included reporting on the many rock-cut caves that now came to light in the mountains around Poona (now Pune), and making eye-copies of their inscriptions.

Sykes’s letter included two drawings of the inscriptions which lined the two side walls of the Naneghat Cave. Owing to the monsoon rains entering the west-facing chamber these had suffered ‘great obliterations’, although in Sykes’s view they had also been crudely incised, which he attributed to carelessness. ‘They bear marks of having been quickly done, as a person writes when careless or in haste,’ he